Babylonian. Later, such inscriptions were engraved further west, such as for example those of the reign of Artaxerxes III (425–338 BCE), the eleventh emperor of the Achaemenid empire. These are at Sardis and Xanthos in Turkey. Literary references to such inscriptions also abound, and, if Herodotus is to believed, stelae with inscriptions in cuneiform and Greek were set up at the site of the Darius bridge around the Bosphorus.[21] Clearly, this template enjoyed wide currency in the regions west of Afghanistan and beyond much before it was deployed for the Ashokan message at Kandahar.

The use of Greek alongside Aramaic by a Pataliputra-based emperor shows us that at least part of his audience was Greek-speaking. That Kandahar had such speakers is also known from a Greek inscription found at old Kandahar, recovered a few hundred yards from Ashoka's bilingual rock edict and inscribed on a statue base. It mentions a Greek-speaking citizen who describes himself as the 'son of Aristonax, one of Alexandria's citizens'.[22] Thus, the first citizen of that city known to history was a Greek. The partially surviving epigraph suggests that he dedicated what may have been the statue of a 'beast' to what is called a 'temenos' of Alexander. A temenos was likely to have been a kind of sanctuary or area dedicated to a Greek deity, which means that not only did this city have Greek inhabitants, it also had structures associated with Greek life.[23] There were Greek settlers in other parts of Afghanistan as well, as at Ai Khanoum in Bactria, a Hellenic city that flourished from times somewhat later than those of Alexander.

Before the arrival of Greek, Achaemenian Aramaic, the language of official communications in the Persian empire, was in use here. In the second half of the first millennium BCE, Aramaic had become the most widely used script across the ancient Near East, from Assyria to north-west India, as well as in Egypt and Asia Minor, because this was what officialdom used.[24] Presumably, it was introduced by the Achaemenids into their satrapies in Afghanistan and the Indus valley, roughly from Arachosia